

A Mornington Peninsula *Winter*

Cellar doors with fires lit, hot springs steaming, and the back-bay walks that win when the bay is grey.

Eight pages · Six venues · One sample weekend · Updated May 2026

Winter is the under-rated Peninsula season.

Summer is busy. Autumn is the postcard. Winter is when the Peninsula's real character holds: ridge mornings under fog, fireplaces in cellar doors, the hot springs reading like a destination instead of a queue. The summer crowds have left, the cellar door staff have time, and a serious dining room is bookable on a Saturday.

This is a short, deliberately opinionated guide. Six venues we'd commit to in winter, framed by a sample two-night plan. It is not exhaustive; it is editorial. Use it like a glove-box reference — print it, keep it in the car, ignore it the moment a local barista tells you something better.

The six

1. Montalto Vineyard & Olive Grove

\$\$\$ · RED HILL

Single Vineyard Pinot Noir and a Sunday lunch beneath the olive grove canopy

2. Ten Minutes by Tractor

\$\$\$\$ · MAIN RIDGE

Estate-grown pinot noir alongside a seasonal degustation rooted in the Ridge vineyard

3. Jackalope Hotel

\$\$\$\$ · RED HILL

A dramatic art-led design hotel set inside a working vineyard, with Doot Doot Doot's eight-metre chandelier overhead

4. Paringa Estate

\$\$\$ · RED HILL

A serious single-vineyard producer with one of the Peninsula's most dependable restaurant terraces

5. Pt. Leo Estate

\$\$\$ · MERRICKS

A sculpture park walk followed by a long bay-view lunch in the glass-walled restaurant

6. Polperro

\$\$\$ · RED HILL

Small-production cool-climate pinot and chardonnay poured in one of the prettiest tasting rooms on the ridge

A sample winter weekend

Friday evening

Drive down. Dinner near the hotel — keep it small after the freeway. A glass at the bar, an early night. The point of Friday is being on the Peninsula by sleep.

Saturday morning

Coffee, a short bay walk, then the ridge. Aim for the cellar doors that face north — the winter sun on the deck is the whole game. Lunch at one of the six.

Saturday afternoon

The hot springs at 3 pm. The light starts dropping by 4:30 in winter; the steam reads as theatre. Reset, dinner is the second event of the day not the first.

Sunday morning

Slow breakfast. A back-bay walk if the wind allows; a museum or gallery if not. Lunch is light and on the way home — Frankston coffee or a Mornington bakery, then the freeway by 2 pm.

Peninsula Insider is independent. Every venue here was visited by the editorial desk. No paid placements. Read the Methodology at peninsulainsider.com.au/methodology.

This guide was produced May 2026 and reflects the editorial corpus as of that date. The live site supersedes; check before you book.